

Inside out

Redressing Mies van der Rohe's maxim 'less is more,' Venturi declared 'less is a bore'. It was intended to be flippant, but it endured in the light of postmodernism. Though it merely expressed his observation that styles come and go, Venturi's phrase came to be seen as encompassing many buildings that ignored architectural norms, such as the Pompidou Centre in Paris (1971–77), designed by Renzo Piano, Richard Rogers and Gianfranco Franchini (1938–2009). The huge modern art museum is a particularly overt example of what became known as an 'inside out' design – or 'bowellism'. Created as a monument to the late French president Georges Pompidou (1911–74), the multi-storey Pompidou Centre (opposite) is supported by an exoskeleton, and all elements that would normally be concealed inside, such as heating and cooling ducts, water pipes and electrical wiring, are on the outside, making space for the open-plan interiors. Each element is independent of all the others; even the escalators that zigzag up the façade can be shortened or lengthened as needed.

